Safe System of Work
The Use of Step Ladders

Ref. SSoW-002	Author.	Lee Hardy	Date:	01.09.2022

Reviewed By: Name	Derick Bibby	Date of Review:	29.08.2026
Record of Amendments			

	Next Review Due Date:	31.08.2027

Overview

The following information provides guidance on the company's Safe System of Work for works that involve the use of Step Ladders.

Falls from height are one of the biggest causes of workplace fatalities and major injuries. One of the most common causes are falls from ladders.

All employees have a responsibility for their safety and the safety of others by adhering to these safety systems.

The Operative must always refer to any associated Risk Assessment and Method Statements prior to starting works.

Hazards Identified

- Adverse weather
- Cuts and abrasions
- Falls from height.
- Slips & Trips.

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) Requirements









Rules when using Stepladders.

- Check all four stepladder feet are in contact with the ground and that the Steps are level;
- Only carry light materials and tools;

- Do not overreach;
- Do not stand and work on the top three steps (including a step forming the very top of the stepladder) unless there is a suitable handhold;
- Ensure any locking devices are engaged;
- Try to position the stepladder to face the work activity and not side on. However, there are occasions when a risk assessment may show it is safer to work side on when you cannot engage the stepladder locks to work face on because of space restraints in narrow aisles, but you can fully lock it to work side on;
- Try to avoid work that imposes a side loading, such as side-on drilling through solid materials (e.g. bricks or concrete);
- Where side-on loadings cannot be avoided, you should prevent the steps from tipping over, e.g. by tying the steps. Otherwise, use a more suitable type of access equipment;
- Maintain three points of contact at the working position. This means two feet and one hand, or when both hands need to be free for a brief period, two feet and the body supported by the stepladder.

Do's and Don'ts in the Use of Stepladders

Do's

- **Check step ladder is safe to use.**
- **Ensure mechanisms operate / engage correctly.**
- **Free from damage**
- **Right height for job**
- **Steps are clean.**
- **All four feet are attached and in good condition.**
- **Only use on firm and level base**
- **Ensure all for feet on ground.**
- **Use non-slip device when using on smooth surfaces.**
- **Wear appropriate footwear.**
- **Maintain three points of contact.**
- **Always face the work area**

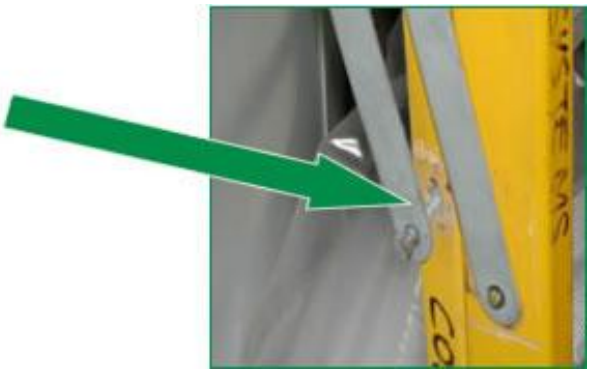
Don'ts

- **Never overreach.**
- **Never exceed the ladder duty rating**
- **Never stand higher than the third rung from top of the step ladder unless it has a designated hand hold.**

Things to look for:

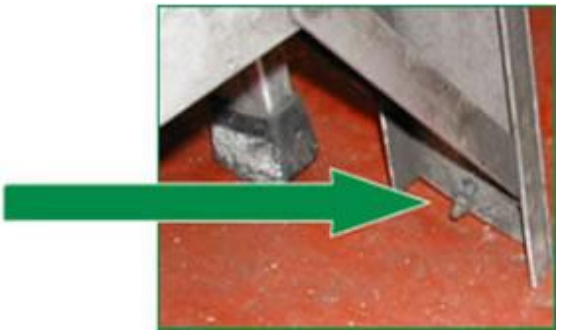
Check the locking bars.

Do not use the stepladder if locking bars are bent or the fixings are worn or damaged as the ladder could collapse.



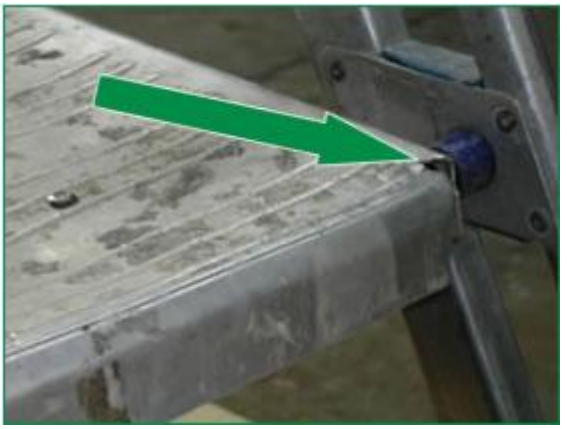
Check the feet.

Do not use the stepladder if feet are missing, worn or damaged as the ladder could slip.



Check the stepladder platform.

Do not use the stepladder if the platform is split or buckled, the stepladder could become unstable or collapse.



Check the steps/treads.
Do not use the stepladder if the steps/treads are contaminated as they could be slippery.

Check the steps for strength and stability.

Do not use the stepladder if the fixings are loose as they could collapse.



Check the stiles.

Do not use the stepladder if stiles are bent or damaged as the ladder could buckle or collapse.

